

Research Proposal

Self-Regulated Learning in Bangladeshi Public University Teacher Education: In Light of Tertiary Level English Language Teaching Context

Course: 508 (A) – Research Methodology

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Date of Submission: 02/10/2022

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Introduction:

Self-regulated learning refers to one's ability to understand and control his/her learning environment. Self-regulated learners set their learning goals; monitor, instruct and reinforce themselves (Harris and Graham, 1999; Schraw, Crippen and Hartley, 2006; Schunk, 1996). Several studies demonstrate that self-regulated learning or competence in learning and self-motivation strategies are significant to elicit high learning outcomes from student teachers and thereby aiding them to be efficient teachers. However, in terms of Bangladeshi public university ELT context, few research projects are accomplished in the field of self-regulated teacher learning. Moreover, although only theoretically, both maximum research projects and Bangladeshi English language teacher education programs focus more on self-regulated learning of the learners rather than that of the teachers. If English language teaching in many of the Bangladeshi public universities is considered it can be discovered that the concept of teacher education is neglected. After finishing their Master's (majority in English literature) students join as lecturers in public universities on the basis of required CGPA. They do not learn self-regulation as student teachers and consequently, most of them end up being teachers who can not connect with their students satisfactorily; whereas proper teacher education makes student teachers aware of their thinking, help them to be strategic and motivated or in a word, it makes them self-regulated learners. Regarding self-regulation, Bangladeshi teacher education programs in public universities are not significantly beneficial to construct student teachers as self-regulated learners. According to Ali and Walker (2014), in Bangladesh teachers often teach in the way they were taught irrespective of changing materials and methods and that is because of inadequate teacher training programs which failed to provide them with understanding of the practical application of theories in classroom. The objective of this research proposal is to find out the extent to which Bangladeshi tertiary level ELT programs facilitate self-regulated learning, reasons inhibiting opportunities of proper self-regulated teacher learning and suggesting ways to implement self-regulated teacher learning in public university ELT programs. This research project is proposed so that the policymakers of public university education, teacher educators and students aspiring to be university teachers might benefit.

There are 3 research questions which will be explored in this study:

- a) Do ELT programs in Bangladeshi public universities contribute to self-regulated learning of the students aspiring to be university teachers?
- b) What are the probable reasons inhibiting proper self-regulated learning of the future university teachers?

c) What are the suggestions to implement self-regulated learning of the future teachers in Bangladeshi public university ELT programs?

Literature Review

According to Boekaerts (1999, as cited in Vrieling et al., 2012) "one of the shared assumptions of social constructivist learning theories is the importance of self-regulated learning (SRL) as the key to successful learning in school and beyond" (p.-103). SRL is a goal-oriented process that proceeds from a forethought phase to self-reflection through self-monitoring and self-control (Pintrich, 2000,2004, as cited in Vrieling et al., 2012). Bereiter and Scardamalia (1993, as cited in Kreber et al., 2005) refer to SRL as "metaknowledge" or "metacognition" since self-regulatory knowledge controls the application of other knowledge. Regarding the consequences of increased self-regulated learning Vrieling et al. (2012) comment, "It was demonstrated that SRL opportunities in learning environments are strongly related to student teachers' use of metacognitive skills and also enhance student teachers' motivation for learning"(p.-114).

According to Shulman (1986, as cited in Keller-Schneider, 2014) in order to be capable of teaching, "students in pre-service education must acquire knowledge in three different categories" and they are- "content knowledge" of the subject matter, "pedagogical knowledge " concerning development, motivation and learning and the "pedagogical content knowledge" of teaching classes and of encouraging students in domain-specific learning processes (p.-145). As stated in Keller-Schneider (2014) "knowledge can be categorised in three types" and among them "propositional or declarative knowledge" is concerned with book-related knowledge (Neuweg, 2011, as cited in Keller-Schneider, 2014), "situated or case knowledge" includes achieving experience as assistant teachers in schools and "professional knowledge", built up in teacher education programs, integrate logic and structure of student teachers' subjective knowledge, concepts and beliefs (p.-146). Keller-Schneider (2014) remarks that in order to make student teachers capable of handling situations professionally linking different types of knowledge " is the central goal of the teacher education programs" (p.-146).

In terms of learners' meaningful accomplishment of learning Eekelen et al. (2005) focus on students' active self-regulation of their learning process and in order to cope with such changing view of teaching-learning process teachers' role has also changed from transmitter of knowledge to supporter and guide of students' self-regulated learning (Vermunt and Verloop, 1999, as cited in Eekelen et al., 2005).

Concerning models of SRL, there are different models and "most models of self-regulation share the same four phases" (Pintrich, 2000; Winne and Perry, 2000; Zimmerman, 2000, as cited in Eekelen et al., 2005, p.-471). Among them phase 1 involves planning and goal-setting as well as activation of perceptions and knowledge of the task, the context and the self in relation to the task; phase 2 concerns various monitoring processes representing metacognitive awareness of the self, the task and the context; phase 3 includes efforts to control and regulate the self or task and context and finally, phase 4 represents various kinds of reactions and reflections on the self and the task or context. The study by Kreber et al. (2005) manifests that involvement in peer

consultation programs, attending workshops on teaching, actively soliciting feedback from students, experimenting with alternative teaching approaches, reading theoretical articles on teaching and learning and attending conferences positively influence self-regulated learning.

If the scholarly comments on self-regulated learning are summarized, it will be discovered that such learning promotes self-management and reflection. However, there is a deficiency in conducting research in the field of self-regulated learning in Bangladeshi public university ELT programs. Although to a very small extent, this proposal will endeavor to contribute to this particular field so that an awareness might grow among concerned people.

Methodology

Instruments:

In order to conduct this study, two types of instruments will be used: questionnaire and interview.

The interviews will be semi-structured, including open-ended questions to allow interviewees to express their thoughts and opinions.

The questionnaire that will be used in this study is a modified version of the "SRL Opportunities Questionnaire" (SRLOQ) developed by Vrieling et al. (2012) (accepted).

Samples:

The samples or participants will consist of 10 students aspiring to be future university teachers. They are required to be connected with ELT programs of any 2 Bangladeshi public universities.

Methods of data collection:

The study will be conducted using both qualitative and quantitative methods.

Participants will be interviewed in mixed code (Bengali and English). Along with semi-structured interviews, the SRLOQ will be used. It includes five scales, namely planning, monitoring learning process, zone of proximal development, coaching and judging and collaboration. The questionnaire will be designed in a semi-structured manner. During designing, subscales under the five super ordinate scales will be considered. Along with interview questions, this instrument is elaborated in the appendix section.

Methods of data analysis:

The questionnaire will be used for quantitative data analysis. Results derived from the questionnaire will aid in discovering the degree of self-regulated learning facilitated by Bangladeshi public university ELT programs.

The qualitative data will be analyzed on the basis of the interviews concerning restrictions and suggestions. The interviews will be transcribed verbatim, translated into English for purposes of data analysis and reporting. After this step, the content will be analyzed following the approach suggested by Miles and Huberman (1994, as cited in Kremer-Hayon and Tillema, 1998). In the first order analysis each idea or thought will constitute a unit of analysis where the remarks derived from each unit will be grouped according to similarities of meaning and classified under common denominator categories. Following this, in the second order analysis the categories will be classified within some frames and finally, there will be a summary of the entire process.

Implications

This research project is proposed to benefit the improvement of ELT programs in Bangladeshi public universities. The policymakers and instructors connected with such programs will be able to modify syllabus and teaching style. Apart from this, students willing to be future university teachers might modify their learning styles for better results. Moreover, this study might create a path for further research on how to increase self-regulated learning and its consequences in Bangladeshi tertiary level ELT context.

Limitations

For temporal, financial and other limitations the study will be conducted only in two Bangladeshi public universities. Also, it will explore only the degree of self-regulated learning, inhibiting reasons and possible solutions but not the ways to increase SRL. Future research projects in the field of SRL might explore this aspect in the context of more Bangladeshi public universities.

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Appendix

Questionnaire

- a) Do ELT programs in Bangladeshi public universities contribute to self-regulated learning of the students aspiring to be university teachers?
 1. Do you want to be a university teacher in the future?
 2. Goal setting (under "Planning")
 - Does the handbook include specific learning goals for all the courses?
 - Do you set your personal learning goals while studying? (If yes, please elaborate considering any one course)
 - Do personal goals harmonize with the goals described in the manual? (If yes, please elaborate considering the same course)
 3. Metacognitive knowledge activation (under "Planning")
 - Do you get assignments from the teachers?
 - Do you divide big assignments into smaller parts?
 4. Time management (under "Planning")

- Do you make a time plan to master the learning goals of the courses?

5. Metacognitive awareness and monitoring of cognition (under "Monitoring of the learning process")

- Does the handbook describe how you can illustrate the progress of any course?
- Can you describe your progress based on obvious criteria? (If yes, please elaborate for any one course)

6. Prior knowledge activation (under "Zone of proximal development")

- Do you get access to relevant documents before the lesson starts?
- Do you feel any change in your thinking and acting due to the obtained new knowledge and skills ? (If yes, please elaborate for any one course)
- Are you allowed to suggest new subjects to be included in a particular course?

7. Perceptions of task difficulty (under "Zone of proximal development")

- Do you feel challenged by the assignments?

8. Metacognitive awareness and monitoring of cognition (under "Coaching/judging")

- Do you get feedback on your learning progress and assignments?
- Do you get feedback on your tests?
- Do you get the opportunity to meet your instructors to ask questions about your progress?

9. Judging (under "Coaching/judging")

- Does the handbook clarify how you can grade your progress for any course?
- Can you describe strong and weak points based on judging criteria? (If yes, please elaborate for any one course)

10. Collaboration

- Do you divide tasks and report to peers (two/more than two) during learning a course?
- Do you have any other collaborative strategy other than the above mentioned points? (If yes, please mention and explain briefly)

Interview

b) What are the probable reasons inhibiting proper self-regulated learning of the future university teachers?

c) What are the suggestions to implement self-regulated learning of the future teachers in Bangladeshi public university ELT programs?